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Serve the Poor

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Serve the Poor

Today's Reading: John 12:1-8

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"Jesus said, 'Leave her alone, so that she may keep it for the day of my burial. For the poor you always have with you, but you do not always have me.'"

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Mary had just expressed complete devotion to Jesus by anointing his head and feet with expensive perfume. It was valued at around a year's salary.

Judas objected loudly. He said the perfume should have been sold so this large amount of money could be given to the poor. But John noted in his Gospel that Judas was not concerned for the poor. Rather, Judas didn't want money wasted that he could possibly pilfer from their treasury.

Jesus told Judas to leave Mary alone. He had no right to condemn her for her benevolent act. Indeed, when anyone would read about Mary's act in the future, it would serve to remind him of what true devotion to the Lord looks like.

Jesus then told Judas that the poor would always be in their midst. He was alluding to Deuteronomy 15:11—the reality that poverty will exist on earth until he returns again.

The causes of poverty are many. Some people are poor because of their irresponsible, indolent choices. Others are the working poor, who try very hard to make ends meet each day. They are desperately trying to keep their head above water. Others are true victims of economic disasters, war, genocide, or diseases. Still others are trapped in a sinister system and cycle of poverty.

No matter what the causes, Jesus calls us to care for those who are broken, powerless, and voiceless. Unless they are able-bodied and refuse to work, we are called to help them. And remember this teaching from Jesus himself: When you look into their faces, remember you are looking into his face. When you serve them, you are serving him.

Jesus wants you to be his hands and feet to the poor around the world. One of the names of his church is “the body of Christ.” On earth, you are Christ’s representative to broken people. Your feet are his feet taking you to them. Your hands are his hands touching their needs. Your voice is his voice giving them hope.

One day, Jesus will return and eradicate all poverty. None of his children should be hungry, thirsty, sick, or destitute. In his soon-arriving kingdom, there will be perfect righteousness and justice. Every need will be met. Every body will be healed. Every heart will be whole. Every person will be fed. Those who thirst will be satisfied.

There will be no poverty at all.

Until that day, pray and work hard to advance Christ’s kingdom on earth. When he returns, let him find you working for this end— especially among the poor.

If you help the poor, you are lending to the Lord—and he will repay you! When you feed the poor and help those in trouble, your light will shine forth in the darkness.

And when you look into the faces of the poor, you will see the face of Jesus.

To serve the poor is God’s will for you today—until Jesus comes again and the poor will no longer be among you.

[from “*Hearing the Voice of God*” by Pastor David Chadwick, *Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC*]